

Chimpanzee

Pan troglodytes

Our closest living relatives, chimpanzees are great apes that share numerous features with humans, such as large brains, expressive faces, a prominent “brow ridge” over the eyes, and dextrous hands with opposable thumbs. They also share some human biology—they go bald and get arthritis with old age, and suffer many human diseases. They display some aspects of human behavior, too, such as an ability to walk upright and play.

Making and using tools

Chimpanzees live in communities of about 35 members, although exceptionally large groups may have up to 150. Active by day, they spend half of it foraging in the forest for plants and animals. Some groups are known to eat as many as 200 types of food. Each evening, they construct sleeping nests in treetops.

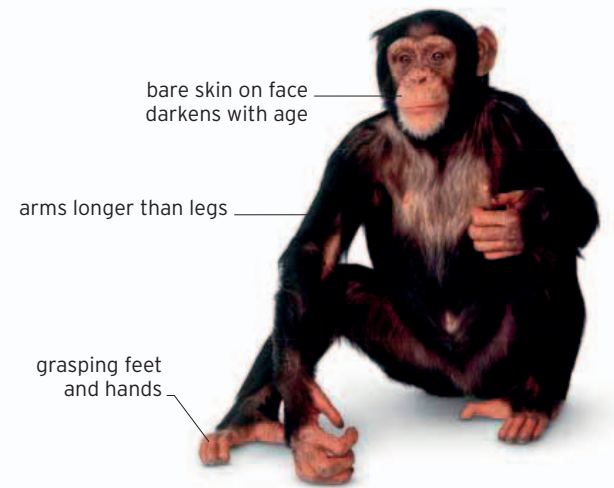
British primatologist Jane Goodall’s study at Gombe Stream, Tanzania, found that chimpanzees band together to hunt other primates, mainly colobus monkeys. Males do most of the hunting, and share the meat with the group. Goodall was also the first to record tool use in chimpanzees—they deploy stone anvils to crack nuts, hold up leaves as umbrellas, and use sticks to fish termites out of tree trunks or extract honey from bees’ nests.

Chimpanzees share more than 98.5 percent of their DNA with humans

Females are sexually mature at between seven and eight years old, but only bear their first single infant at 13–14 years, after a gestation of about eight months. Babies are dependent on their mothers, sharing the maternal nest at night, and are weaned when four or five years old. Juveniles learn tool-use and other complex behavior by watching older relatives. If food is plentiful, chimpanzees can breed all year round.

Fragmented range

Up to the early 1900s, chimpanzees occurred throughout the tropical forests of West and Central Africa. Today their range is highly fragmented due to decades of deforestation, capture for zoos, circuses, and medical research, and hunting for the bushmeat trade. About 200,000–300,000 remain in the wild, and populations continue to fall.

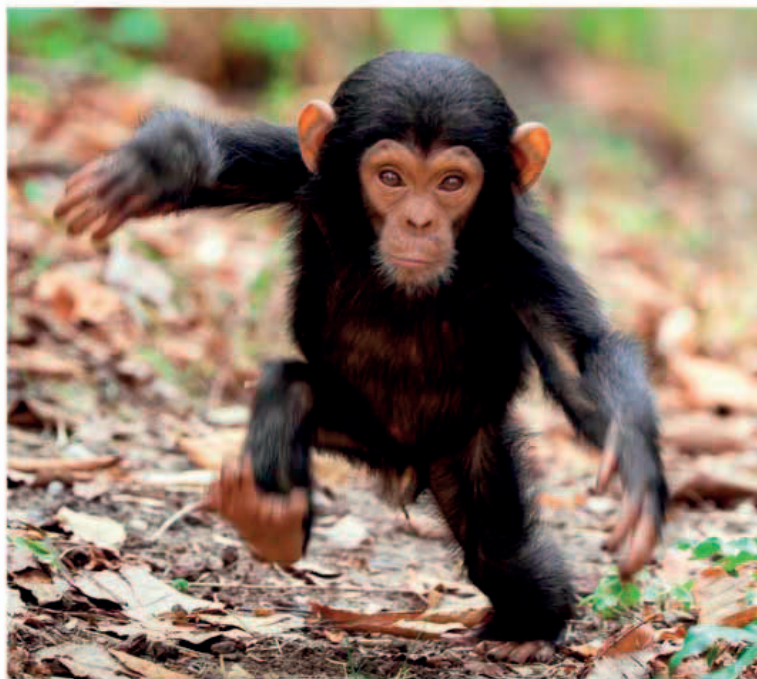


△ BONOBO

Bonobos, or pygmy chimpanzees (*P. paniscus*), are more agile than chimpanzees, and spend more time walking upright. They are rarer, confined to the Congo Basin, where about 30,000 may survive.

▷ BABY CHIMPANZEE

Young chimps are inquisitive and playful, engaging in frequent bouts of roughhousing with playmates of their age.



▷ HIGHLY INTELLIGENT

After humans, chimpanzees are the most intelligent primate, with a sophisticated language of facial expressions, gestures, and vocalizations. They may live more than 50 years in the wild.

- ↔ 25–37 in (64–94 cm)
- ⚖ 66–130 lb (30–60 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🌿 Plants, animals
- 🏠 🏠



W. and
C. Africa